

language appears to have the upper hand will suddenly draw people in droves; its usage will spread like an epidemic, and other languages will be rapidly dislodged. I am often amazed to listen to conversations between people from two neighboring countries, say, between a Turk and an Iranian, or a Lebanese and a Cypriot, communicating in bad English, moving their hands for emphasis, searching for these words that come out of their throats at the cost of great physical effort. Even members of the Swiss Army use English (not French) as a lingua franca (it would be fun to listen). Consider that a very small minority of Americans of northern European descent is from England; traditionally the preponderant ethnic groups are of German, Irish, Dutch, French, and other northern European extraction. Yet because all these groups now use English as their main tongue, they have to study the roots of their adoptive tongue and develop a cultural association with parts of a particular wet island, along with its history, its traditions, and its customs!

Ideas and Contagions

The same model can be used for the contagions and concentration of ideas. But there are some restrictions on the nature of epidemics I must discuss here. Ideas do not spread without some form of structure. Recall the discussion in [Chapter 4](#) about how we come prepared to make inferences. Just as we tend to generalize some matters but not others, so there seem to be “basins of attraction” directing us to certain beliefs. Some ideas will prove contagious, but not others; some forms of superstitions will spread, but not others; some types of religious beliefs will dominate, but not others. The anthropologist, cognitive scientist, and philosopher Dan Sperber has proposed the following idea on the epidemiology of representations. What people call “memes,” ideas that spread and that compete with one another using people as carriers, are not truly like genes. Ideas spread because, alas, they have for carriers self-serving agents who are interested in them, and interested in distorting them in the replication process. You do not make a cake for the sake of merely replicating a recipe—you try to make *your* own cake, using ideas from others to improve it. We humans are not photocopiers. So contagious mental categories must be those in which we are prepared to believe, perhaps even programmed to believe. To be contagious, a mental category must agree with our nature.

NOBODY IS SAFE IN EXTREMISTAN

There is something extremely naïve about all these models of the dynamics of concentration I’ve presented so far, particularly the socioeconomic ones. For instance, although Merton’s idea includes luck, it misses an additional layer of randomness. In all these models the winner stays a winner. Now, a loser might